would do to the Americans what they had done to the Soviet Union and place his nuclear missiles on the shores of Cuba. “It was during my visit to Bulgaria that I had the idea of installing missiles with nuclear warheads in Cuba,” wrote Khrushchev in his memoirs. This looked like a solution to both of his problems, protecting Cuba and bridging the missile gap with the United States. “Khrushchev had a rich imagination, and when some idea took hold of him, he was inclined to see in its implementation an easy solution to a particular problem, a sort of cure-all,” recalled the Soviet leader’s assistant, Oleg Troianovsky.[18]

Khrushchev had found the “cure-all” on the shores of the Black Sea. While he lacked long-range ballistic missiles, he had plenty of short-and medium-range ones, designed and produced by Mikhail Yangel at the Dnipropetrovsk works that Khrushchev had visited in the summer of 1959. The missiles that he bragged the Soviets could allegedly produce like sausages were R-12 or SS-4 Sandals, capable of reaching targets within a 2,000-kilometer range. In 1962 the army had begun the deployment of R-14 or SS-5 Skean intermediate missiles with an operational range of 3,700 kilometers. By installing those short- and medium-range missiles in Cuba, Khrushchev could reach American targets. It looked like the perfect solution.[19]

On the flight back to Moscow, Khrushchev approached his foreign minister, Andrei Gromyko, for a private conversation. “The situation that has now developed around Cuba is dangerous,” Khrushchev told his surprised colleague. “To save it as an independent state we must install a number of our nuclear rockets there. I think that’s the only thing that can save the country. Washington will not be deterred by last year’s failed intervention at Playa Girón.” Khrushchev asked Gromyko for his opinion. The foreign minister was less than enthusiastic, but not yet having become a member of the Presidium and thus of the high Soviet leadership, was more than cautious in expressing his concern. “I should say frankly,” wrote Gromyko, recalling his words, “that bringing our nuclear missiles to Cuba will cause a political explosion in the United States.” Khrushchev was not pleased but did not rebuke his foreign minister. After a pause, he told Gromyko: “We don’t need a nuclear war, and we are not about to fight.” Gromyko was relieved.[20]